

The Game Changers INSTITUTIONS

VATSA, TYAGI AND KAPUR'S ENDEAVOURS HAVE HELPED 55,000 STUDENTS IN JHALAWAR AND KOTA



REUBEN SINGH

RITINJALI Rajasthan

MISSIONARIES OF CLARITY

Whenever Arun Kapur has an impossible task, he calls on Himanshu Tyagi, an actor who has done his M. Phil from Jawaharlal Nehru University (JNU). First it was to organise workshops for 16-21-year-olds in Tihar jail, and now it is government teacher training workshops in Jhalawar and Kota districts of Rajasthan, that cover about 55,000 students between the ages of 12 and 14. Working in close consultation with the district magistrate of Jhalawar since 2007, Kapur, who runs an NGO Ritinjali in the time he has to spare from his primary role as director, Vasant Valley School, Delhi, devised a role play format for training master trainers who, in turn, will train teachers of classes VII and VIII of all the 1,228 government schools in the two districts. Joined by Tyagi's actor wife, Shalini Vatsa, who like him has also been trained in theatre in education

with Barry John, they would go to the district institute of educational training (DIET) and conduct 12-day programmes. "The idea was to tell the teachers how to become better human beings and instill an empathy in them for the adolescents they were teaching," says Tyagi, who lives in Mumbai. "They started by wanting notes notes and by the end of it, they were participating in class discussions," says Vatsa, adding, "They are simply teach-

Teachers from **1,228** government schools in Kota and Jhalawar have been benefited by the workshops.

ers whom the system has failed." Ritinjali helps others dubbed failures as well. At its second chance school in Delhi, a maximum of 20 students are enrolled in the National Institute of Open Schooling as well as trained in occupations such as tailoring and autocar repair.

by Kaveri Bamzai

KANAVU, Kerala

CULTURE CLUB

Dreams do not always come true. But this one is an exception. Nestled in the lush green Cheengode hills in Wayanad district, Kanavu (meaning dream) is a school for the local tribal children. Set up by writer and activist Kochupoovathinkal Joseph Baby, 54, with wife Shirley, 50, the school helps the tribals capture the essence of their own tradition. Kanavu is located on a lush green six-acre land, purchased by a grant from Vistaar, a Bangalore-based NGO. The school has neither a syllabus nor does it issue certificates to those who pass out. Here the tribal children learn traditional songs, dance, drawing, cooking

So far, about **70 students** have studied at Kanavu.

and their arts and crafts, besides reading, writing and even computers and filmmaking. Ayurveda and Kalarippayattu (martial arts) are also part of the curriculum. The cultural programmes presented by Kanavu students is another high point of the school and are hugely popular in Kerala. A major source of revenue is generated through these programmes that are also staged outside the state. As of now, the school has about 22 students. Some of its former students are now working with a Gandhian voluntary organisation as handloom workers. "They all send a share of the money they make to sponsor one or two children. The alumni also take turns to return to work in Kanavu for three years," says Chipran, a student and an artist. by M.G. Radhakrishnan

